

POLITICS OF SEPARATION

Parties gear up for a tough triangular battle in the upcoming by-elections that are being seen as a referendum on statehood for Telangana. Much depends on TRS's ability to retain its constituencies.

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

For the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) it is virtually a referendum on carving a separate state out of Andhra Pradesh. With by-elections to 18 Assembly constituencies and four Lok Sabha seats scheduled for May 29, retaining all the seats is a Herculean task for the party. TRS legislators resigned en masse recently to protest the UPA Government's failure to award separate statehood to Telangana, vacating 16 Assembly and four Lok Sabha seats. Having decided to field all of them again, TRS can only hope that the Telangana sentiment in favour of a separate state will muster enough votes. The ruling Congress and the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) are poised to retain the other two constituencies, in which the death of party incumbents has forced by-elections.

TRS supremo K. Chandrasekhara Rao, however, is upbeat. "Rivals will forfeit their deposits. The people of the region have been betrayed and know that their future will be bright only in a separate Telangana state," says Rao, who is travelling extensively through all the 42 constituencies in the hope of scoring a victory. But the gimmicks he's resorting to—having a bath in the open in a village, making tea at a wayside stall and staying in a tribal hamlet on the eve of Ugadi, the Telugu new year's day, with a camera trained on him throughout—give him away. TRS is on slippery ground, as anti-incumbency is likely to hurt the party's prospects badly in six to eight of the 16 constituencies that it is trying to retain.

For the Congress and Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, it is a question of prestige. Reddy, who

LOCKING HORNS: Rao rides a bullock cart as part of his campaign



Photographs by A PRABHAKAR RAO

cannot afford to let the Telangana sentiment override his slogan of development, launched the Rs 2-a-kilo rice scheme on April 9, ahead of the announcement of the poll schedule. Apprehensive about how his party will fare, Reddy has roped in ministers and influential MLAs to oversee the campaign in all constituencies, cautioning them that if they don't put up a good show, they could lose out on party tick-

ets for the 2009 Assembly elections.

It is easy to see where this worry stems from. In the last two decades—except in two constituencies, Mydaram and Mushirabad—the Congress has never won any of the 16 Assembly constituencies for two consecutive terms. Its tally dropped to just two in 1994 from seven in 1989 and showed no improvement in 1999. The party has had a poor record since it handed over the constituencies in the region to TRS to contest as part of the 2004 poll pact between them. With the Congress learning from past experience that it is better to rely on a strong leader than to shuffle chief ministers,

"There is a strong sentiment for a new state, but the overriding factor will be development."

Y.S. RAJASEKHARA REDDY, CHIEF MINISTER

